

ANSWER KEY & MODEL ANSWERS

UPSC Mock Examination — International Relations, South Asia & Current Affairs

Date: 14 June 2026 | Maximum Marks: 165 | Strictly for Self-Evaluation Only

QUICK ANSWER GRID — SECTION A (Q1–Q35)

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	A	2	B	3	C	4	D	5	A
6	B	7	C	8	D	9	A	10	B
11	C	12	D	13	A	14	B	15	C
16	D	17	A	18	B	19	C	20	D
21	B	22	C	23	D	24	A	25	B
26	C	27	D	28	A	29	B	30	C
31	D	32	A	33	B	34	C	35	D

Scoring: +2.00 per correct MCQ | –0.66 per wrong MCQ | 0 for unattempted | Max Section A = 70 marks | Net score = (Correct × 2) – (Wrong × 0.66)

SECTION A — MCQ EXPLANATIONS (Q1–Q35)

■ Part A-1 — Conceptual (Q1–10)

Q1. Correct Answer: (A) +2.00

Why others are wrong: B = bipolarity/balance of power; C = liberal institutionalism; D = multipolarity.

Unipolarity describes the post-Cold War US-led order where a single state held unchallenged preponderance across military, economic and diplomatic domains. The US moment of unipolarity (1991–2008 approximately) is the textbook example. The concept is associated with Charles Krauthammer's 'Unipolar Moment' (1990/1991).

Q2. Correct Answer: (B) +2.00

Why others are wrong: A = India has NOT joined formal military alliances (no treaty obligations); C = India has NOT abandoned peaceful coexistence; D = multi-alignment also prioritises security, not just economy.

Multi-alignment is India's post-Cold War, post-NAM evolution. It is characterised by issue-based partnerships with competing powers — defence with USA, energy with Russia, civil nuclear with France — while retaining freedom of action. It is NOT a formal alliance system. The term was popularised by EAM Jaishankar in 'The India Way' (2020).

Q3. Correct Answer: (C) +2.00

Why others are wrong: No statements are wrong: all three — G4, UfC composition, and Charter amendment requirement — are correctly stated.

UNSC reform requires: (1) 2/3 of 193 UNGA members, AND (2) ratification by all P5 (Art. 108 UN Charter). G4 = India+Brazil+Germany+Japan advocate permanent seats. UfC (Italy, Pakistan, South Korea, Argentina, Mexico, Spain etc.) opposes new permanent members — they fear regional rivals gaining permanent seats. This makes UNSC reform practically very difficult.

Q4. Correct Answer: (D) +2.00

Why others are wrong: A, B and C place the conflicts in wrong order.

Correct order: (1) First Kashmir War / Op Polo — following Independence + PoK incursion by Pakistan-backed tribals; (2) Second India-Pakistan War — triggered by Operation Gibraltar (Pakistan's infiltration in J&K) and Operation Grand Slam; (3) Bangladesh Liberation War — India's intervention after Pakistan's Operation Searchlight, resulting in Bangladesh's creation; (4) Kargil Conflict / Operation Vijay — Pakistan's NLI soldiers occupied Kargil heights, India recaptured all peaks.

Q5. Correct Answer: (A) +2.00

Why others are wrong: B = no such 90-day plebiscite was explicitly in the Instrument; C = Indian Independence Act allowed Princely States to accede to either dominion OR remain independent; D = Pakistan protested to the UN Security Council (not General Assembly).

The Instrument of Accession was signed on 26 October 1947 — the same day Pakistani-backed tribal forces (lashkars) were approaching Srinagar. It acceded only on three subjects: Defence, External Affairs and Communications. Mountbatten's acceptance letter mentioned a plebiscite 'once order is restored' — but this was conditional, not a term of the Instrument.

Q6. Correct Answer: (B) +2.00

Why others are wrong: A = Statements 1 & 2 are correct but omits Statement 3 (World Bank IS a party). D = Statement 4 is wrong — IWT has its own three-tier dispute resolution: Permanent Indus Commission → Neutral Expert → Court of Arbitration. ICJ is not the mechanism.

IWT 1960 gives India the three eastern rivers (Ravi, Beas, Sutlej) and Pakistan the three western rivers (Indus, Jhelum, Chenab). The World Bank was the mediator AND is listed as a party in the Treaty text — an unusual arrangement. The Treaty's own dispute resolution escalates from Permanent Indus Commission (biannual meetings) → Neutral Expert (technical) → Court of Arbitration (legal). India and Pakistan are currently in dispute before the Permanent Court of Arbitration (The Hague) on Kishenganga and Ratle HPPs.

Q7. Correct Answer: (C) +2.00

Why others are wrong: A, B and D are all genuine reasons for SAARC's failure.

SAARC DOES have a permanent Secretariat, established in Kathmandu in 1987 with a Secretary-General. So (C) is factually wrong — making it the correct answer to 'which is NOT a reason'. The real reasons for SAARC's paralysis are: India-Pakistan tensions (no summit since 2016), consensus-based decision-making giving veto to all members, and absence of a dispute resolution mechanism unlike ASEAN's AIPA or WTO-style panels.

Q8. Correct Answer: (D) +2.00

Why others are wrong: A = Statement 4 is wrong (Shimla did NOT recognise Pakistan's Kashmir claim — it rejected UN-supervised plebiscite mechanism). B and C also include Statement 4.

Shimla Agreement (July 2, 1972): Indira Gandhi + Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. Key outcomes: (1) Ceasefire line → Line of Control (LoC); (2) Bilateral resolution of all disputes — Pakistan gave up the 1948 UN Security Council plebiscite mechanism; (3) PoWs released (93,000 Pakistani soldiers). Statement 4 is wrong: Shimla explicitly rejected third-party mediation and the UN plebiscite route — it did NOT recognise Pakistan's claim.

Q9. Correct Answer: (A) +2.00

Why others are wrong: B = about domestic instability, not the paradox; C = about arsenal asymmetry; D = incorrectly describes Pakistan's doctrine causing India's NFU problem.

The Stability-Instability Paradox (Glenn Snyder, 1965) applied to South Asia means: Nuclear deterrence prevents full-scale conventional war (strategic stability), but paradoxically this stability ENABLES sub-conventional conflict because the aggressor calculates that the deterred party cannot escalate conventionally for fear of nuclear escalation. Pakistan's sponsorship of groups like LeT (Mumbai 2008) and JeM (Pulwama 2019) under the nuclear umbrella is the textbook South Asian manifestation.

Q10. Correct Answer: (B) +2.00

Why others are wrong: A = wrong region — CPEC does NOT pass through Aksai Chin (which is already Chinese-held); C = CPEC is funded through Chinese debt, NOT grants — Pakistan faces debt trap concerns; D = CPEC originates from Kashgar (Xinjiang), not Yunnan, and goes to Gwadar (not Karachi).

India's official objection is sovereignty-based: CPEC passes through Gilgit-Baltistan, which India considers its own territory (part of J&K pre-reorganisation). India conveyed this to China formally in 2017 at the UN. The CPEC also has strategic concerns: it reduces Pakistan's debt autonomy, deepens China-Pakistan military nexus, and the Gwadar port gives China Indian Ocean access near India's western coast.

■ Part A-2 — Advanced / Application (Q11–20)

Q11. Correct Answer: (C) +2.00

Why others are wrong: A = only describes Pakistan-specific nuclear deterrence, not the two-front concept; B = conflates internal security with external military challenge; D = same.

India's two-front challenge refers to the de facto strategic axis between China and Pakistan. The 2020 Galwan clash and Pakistan's continued proxy war simultaneously demonstrated this vulnerability. India's military doctrine (Cold Start + Mountain Strike Corps) has to account for simultaneous conventional threats from two nuclear-armed adversaries. Chief of Defence Staff Bipin Rawat formally acknowledged this in public in 2021.

Q12. Correct Answer: (D) +2.00

Why others are wrong: All four pairs are correctly matched — no option is wrong.

Verification: (1) Neighbourhood First — connectivity + development aid + people ties ✓; (2) BIMSTEC — Bangladesh, India, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Thailand, Nepal, Bhutan = 7 members, Bay of Bengal, no Pakistan ✓; (3) Gujral Doctrine (I.K. Gujral, 1996) — non-reciprocity towards smaller neighbours ✓; (4) Act East (PM Modi, 2014 ASEAN summit) — expanded Look East with military + strategic dimensions ✓.

Q1 Correct Answer: (A) +2.00
3.

Why others are wrong: Statement 1 is WRONG — India re-opened its embassy in Kabul and re-established a diplomatic presence (first technical mission by June 2022, embassy re-opened 2023). Statements 2 and 3 are correct.

India's post-Taliban strategy is nuanced: (a) India did NOT formally recognise the Taliban government but re-established contact; (b) India values Afghanistan as a gateway to Central Asia through the INSTC (Chabahar port → Afghanistan → Central Asia corridor); (c) Pakistan benefits from reduced Indian influence — Taliban's return weakens India's development investment (Salma Dam, Afghan Parliament building, roads).

Q1 Correct Answer: (B) +2.00
4.

Why others are wrong: A = India maintains NFU, not first use; C = Nuclear Command Authority is chaired by the PM (not Defence Minister); D = India has no declared tactical/battlefield nuclear weapons.

India's nuclear doctrine (August 1999 draft, formally issued 2003): (1) No First Use; (2) Credible Minimum Deterrence; (3) Massive retaliation (not proportional) if India suffers nuclear strike; (4) No-first-use against non-nuclear states; (5) Nuclear Command Authority = Political Council (PM as Chair) + Executive Council (NSA as Chair).

Q1 Correct Answer: (C) +2.00
5.

Why others are wrong: All three statements are contributing factors — none is wrong.

Supply-chain security became a top national security issue after: (1) COVID-19 (2020) showed ~70% of API (Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients) came from China; (2) Semiconductor shortage (2020-22) affected 169 industries including F-35 fighter jets and automobiles; (3) Rare earth monopoly: China processes ~85% of global rare earths critical for EV batteries, wind turbines, missile guidance. This triggered US CHIPS Act, India's Production Linked Incentives, EU Critical Raw Materials Act.

Q1 Correct Answer: (D) +2.00
6.

Why others are wrong: A = Indo-Pacific was first used by Japan's PM Abe (2007) and popularised by India's PM Modi at Shangri-La Dialogue 2018 — not in Act East 2014; B = QUAD is NOT a formal alliance (no Article 5 equivalent); C = China actively opposes QUAD.

The Indo-Pacific framework: (1) Links Indian Ocean security with Pacific security; (2) India's SAGAR doctrine (Security and Growth for All in the Region) is its approach; (3) QUAD (India-US-Japan-Australia) is a consultative dialogue, NOT a defence alliance; (4) China criticises it as an 'Asian NATO'; (5) France, UK and Germany have their own Indo-Pacific strategies showing its broad acceptance.

Q1 Correct Answer: (A) +2.00
7.

Why others are wrong: All four statements are correct.

Verification: BIMSTEC 7 members ✓; SCO: India and Pakistan 2017, Iran 2023, Belarus 2024 ✓; Afghanistan joined SAARC as 8th member in 2007 Dhaka Summit ✓; IORA: 23 members from Africa (Kenya, Mozambique), West Asia (Oman, UAE), South Asia (India, Sri Lanka), Southeast Asia (Indonesia, Thailand), Oceania (Australia) ✓. All statements verified correct.

Q1 **Correct Answer: (B) +2.00**
8.

Why others are wrong: A = Lahore Declaration was NOT about ceasefire; C = Pakistan did NOT accept LoC as permanent boundary; D = no CTBT moratorium — India and Pakistan are not CTBT signatories.

Lahore Declaration (February 21, 1999 — Vajpayee's historic bus diplomacy): Committed India and Pakistan to: (1) Nuclear risk reduction measures; (2) Hotline between the two Foreign Secretaries; (3) Advance notification of ballistic missile tests; (4) Peaceful resolution through composite dialogue. The irony: just 3 months later, Pakistan launched the Kargil intrusion (May 1999) — a military plan running parallel to civilian peace outreach.

Q1 **Correct Answer: (C) +2.00**
9.

Why others are wrong: A = India has NOT offered unconditional dialogue (talks are linked to terrorism); B = India explicitly rejects third-party mediation; D = India has demonstrated kinetic options (Balakot airstrikes, Uri surgical strikes).

Strategic patience post-Balakot (February 26, 2019): India struck JeM training camp in Balakot, Pakistan, then stepped back from escalation. The doctrine is: (1) Demonstrate willingness and capability to escalate; (2) Avoid uncontrolled escalation; (3) Use diplomatic isolation (Masood Azhar UNSC listing, FATF grey-listing of Pakistan); (4) Wait for internal contradictions in Pakistan's civil-military compact to force change.

Q2 **Correct Answer: (D) +2.00**
0.

Why others are wrong: A = India does NOT want to dissolve institutions; B = India has NOT demanded elimination of P5 veto; C = India supports multilateral forums, not just bilateralism.

Reformed multilateralism is India's core position at UNGA and G20. It means: (1) UNSC permanent member expansion — India + Brazil + Germany + Japan (G4); (2) IMF quota reform — emerging economies underrepresented relative to GDP share; (3) WTO reform for better representation of developing countries' interests; (4) 'Voice and Representation' for the Global South — India's G20 presidency (2023) made African Union permanent G20 member, reflecting this agenda.

■ Part A-3 — Current Affairs: Week June 7–13, 2026 (Q21–30)

Q2 **Correct Answer: (B) +2.00**
1.

Why others are wrong: A = Hormuz connects Persian Gulf to Gulf of Oman (NOT Red Sea); C = Hormuz is subject to UNCLOS 'transit passage' regime — it CANNOT be suspended by Iran; D = Kharg Island is in the Persian Gulf body, NOT within the Strait itself.

Strait of Hormuz facts: Width = 33-39 km; ~20-22% of global oil + ~20% of global LNG transits it daily; separates Iran from UAE/Oman; UNCLOS Articles 37-38 = transit passage regime applies (all ships/aircraft have right of transit passage, cannot be suspended). Kharg Island (85-95% of Iran's crude oil exports) is located in the northern Persian Gulf, well north of the Strait.

Q2 **Correct Answer: (C) +2.00**
2.

Why others are wrong: A = India invoked consular rights (Vienna Convention Art. 36), not UNCLOS Art. 87; B = vessels were NOT Indian-flagged; D = India summoned US diplomat but did NOT recall its Ambassador.

Flag of Convenience (FOC): Ship registration country ≠ ship owner nationality ≠ crew nationality. MT Settebello, MT Marivex and MT Jalveer were flagged under Palau and Guinea-Bissau. India (~2.5 lakh seafarers = 4th largest maritime manpower supplier) is heavily exposed to this system. India summoned US diplomat twice; invoked Vienna Convention on Consular Relations 1963 Article 36 for consular access to detained/killed Indian nationals. DGS (Directorate General of Shipping) is under Ministry of Ports, Shipping & Waterways — NOT Ministry of Defence.

Q2 **Correct Answer: (D) +2.00**
3.

Why others are wrong: A, B and C are fabricated themes.

The 11th Governing Council of NITI Aayog (June 11, 2026), chaired by PM Modi, had the theme 'Inclusive Human Development for Viksit Bharat @2047'. Key discussions: HP's demand for Revenue Deficit Grant + BBMB arrears; Punjab's Special Category Status demand; Gadgil Formula abolition by 14th FC; ecological services compensation for hill states. NITI Aayog ≠ Constitutional body (established by executive Cabinet Resolution Jan 1, 2015); Article 275 = RDG grants (not NITI Aayog mandate).

Q2 **Correct Answer: (A) +2.00**
4.

Why others are wrong: B = no new delimitation commission created; C = no SEZ announced; D = NSCN (I-M) is not an Assam-government issue — Nagaland/Centre matter.

Assam-Nagaland Disputed Area Belt (DAB): ~150 km strip of territory disputed between both states. Oil exploration has been stalled for 30+ years due to the boundary dispute. The June 2026 tripartite MoU (Assam CM + Nagaland CM + Home Ministry) revives exploration with 50:50 revenue sharing. Potential: from ~1,000-1,500 bpd currently to 10× with proper investment. This is linked to the broader AFSPA de-escalation and peace process in Northeast India.

Q2 **Correct Answer: (B) +2.00**
5.

Why others are wrong: Statement 1 is WRONG: Gig workers are classified as 'self-employed' (NOT employees) under the Code on Social Security — they get a social security fund from aggregators but are NOT entitled to EPF/ESIC as 'employees'. Statements 2 and 3 are correct.

Labour Codes key provisions: (1) Fixed-Term Employment (FTE) — entitled to gratuity pro-rata after 1 year (not 5 years), same wages as permanent staff ✓; (2) Code on Wages: 50% wage rule = allowances cannot exceed 50% of total remuneration ✓; (3) National Floor Wage: States cannot go below Central floor wage ✓; (4) Gig workers: Self-employed status → social security fund (not EPF/ESIC) ← major criticism from labour unions who call it 'permanent temporariness'.

Q2 **Correct Answer: (C) +2.00**
6.

Why others are wrong: Statement 1 is WRONG: Nipah was first identified in Malaysia in 1999 (Sungai Nipah village, Negeri Sembilan). India's first Nipah outbreak was Siliguri 2001 (66 deaths, nosocomial spread). Statements 2 and 3 are correct.

NIV Pune (BSL-4 facility) is India's designated lab for Nipah confirmation ✓. WHO Blueprint Priority Disease = no approved human vaccine or specific antiviral ✓ (m102.4 monoclonal antibody is experimental). Kerala outbreaks: 2018 → 2021 → 2023 → 2026. Nipah CFR: 40-75% globally; Kerala ~30-45% (better early detection). $R_0 \approx 0.5$ (limited human-to-human transmission — danger is CFR, not transmissibility). One Health approach: deforestation → bat habitat loss → human-bat interface ↑ → spillover.

Q2 **Correct Answer: (D) +2.00**
7.

Why others are wrong: A = India's national TFR is 1.9 (NOT above 3.0); B = 84th Amendment froze until first Census AFTER 2026, not permanently; C = partly true but incomplete — southern states' reduced share is the concern, not automatic.

India's TFR reality: National ~1.9 (below replacement 2.1); Bihar ~3.0; UP ~2.7; Tamil Nadu ~1.4; AP ~1.3. 84th Amendment (2001) froze seat allocation using 1971 Census basis until after the first Census post-2026. Now that 2026 has arrived, delimitation will likely use 2031 Census. The federal tension: if seats are purely population-based, BIMARU states gain seats while southern states (which implemented family planning successfully) lose representation — penalising demographic responsibility.

Q2 **Correct Answer: (A) +2.00**
8.

Why others are wrong: B = this is an executive policy directive, not what the SC ruled; C = GDP inclusion is a separate statistical matter; D = insurance companies were not the subject of the ruling.

SC June 2026 ruling (Motor Accident Compensation): Created '**Loss of Domestic Care**' as the 6th distinct MACT compensation head. Fixed ₹30,000/month as minimum notional income for homemakers. Superseded Pranay Sethi (2017) guidelines. Mandatory 10% upward revision every 3 years. Based on: NSSO Time Use Survey 2019 (women = 7.2 hrs/day unpaid work); SDG 5.4 (recognise unpaid care); MV Act 1988 compensation framework. Sarla Verma (2009) dealt with multiplier method for income calculation — different from this ruling.

Q2 **Correct Answer: (B) +2.00**
9.

Why others are wrong: A = 2026 deal includes BOTH IAF Rafale AND Rafale Marine (naval), not exclusively naval; C = the 2016 deal WAS government-to-government (India-France G2G); D = nuclear capability is separate from Jaitapur NPP obstacle.

2016 Rafale deal: 36 fly-away jets (IAF), no Transfer of Technology, government-to-government, ~₹59,000 crore. 2026 Rafale deal: 114 jets (IAF + Rafale Marine for navy), full ToT, up to 90 manufactured in India (HAL/Tata/Mahindra ecosystem), co-production. India-France bilateral upgraded to Special Global Strategic Partnership (SGSP) in 2023 (NOT 1998 — 1998 was 'Strategic Partnership'). Jaitapur NPP obstacle: CLNDA 2010 Section 17(b) — operator-to-supplier recourse clause that French companies refuse.

Q3 **Correct Answer: (C) +2.00**
0.

Why others are wrong: A = CEPA does NOT grant unlimited work permits; B = CEPA with Oman does NOT give automatic GCC-wide access (GCC is a separate organisation); D = no permanent basing rights clause in the public CEPA.

India-Oman CEPA (in force June 1, 2026): 98% tariff lines covered; ~₹12,000 crore bilateral trade. Strategic significance: (1) Duqm port (deep-water, Arabian Sea) — India has access agreement for logistics; (2) Salalah port (near Gulf of Aden); (3) Both ports allow India to route trade bypassing Strait of Hormuz via road/rail to Red Sea. Context: June 2026 Hormuz closure made this CEPA immediately more strategic.

■ **Part A-4 — CSAT (Q31–35)**

Q3 **Correct Answer: (D) +2.00**
1.

Why others are wrong: A = passage explicitly says it evolved FROM Non-Alignment (not identical); B = passage says 'not a doctrine of equidistance' — so B is directly contradicted; C = passage says 'without formal binding commitments' — contradicts alliances.

Reading comprehension: The passage's key phrase is 'It is not a doctrine of equidistance but of equi-engagement.' And: 'without formal binding commitments... preserving freedom of action.' Option D directly paraphrases this: partnerships with multiple powers WITHOUT binding commitments that constrain future choices. This is a direct inference from the passage — no external knowledge required.

Q3 **Correct Answer: (A) +2.00**
2.

Why others are wrong: B = R only says Z had no diplomatic relations LAST YEAR — nothing is said about now; C = cannot be concluded from the premises; D = introduces 'trade offices' — a concept not in any premise.

Logical deduction: P says FTA requires pre-existing diplomatic relations. Q says FTA signed with Y. Therefore (by Modus Ponens): diplomatic relations with Y MUST exist. This is definitively and necessarily true. R (about Country Z) tells us nothing about Z now — only about last year. B, C and D are not necessitated by the premises. Classic deductive logic: if $P \rightarrow Q$ and Q, then P.

Q3 **Correct Answer: (B) +2.00**
3.

Why others are wrong: A = exports DID recover — 2021-22 surpassed 2019-20 levels; C = highest growth RATE was 2020-21 to 2021-22 (54.1%), not 2022-23 to 2023-24 (48.4%); D = ₹23,622 crore is far below the ₹50,000 crore target.

Calculation for B: Growth = $(23,622 - 9,116) / 9,116 \times 100 = 14,506 / 9,116 \times 100 = 159.1\%$. More than doubled ✓. For C check: 2020-21→2021-22 = $(13,000 - 8,435) / 8,435 = 54.1\%$; 2022-23→2023-24 = $(23,622 - 15,920) / 15,920 = 48.4\%$. Highest rate = 2020-21 to 2021-22, NOT 2022-23 to 2023-24. So C is wrong.

Q3 Correct Answer: (C) +2.00

4.

Why others are wrong: A = 37.5% would be 35% + 7% (wrong — 10% of 35% = 3.5%); B = 38% is off; D = 40% would require increase of 5 percentage points (wrong).

Calculation: South Asia = 35% of ■10,000 cr = ■3,500 cr. 10% increase = ■350 cr. New South Asia = ■3,850 cr. Total budget = ■10,000 cr (unchanged). New South Asia % = $3,850/10,000 \times 100 = 38.5\%$ ✓. Common trap: '10% increase' means 10% of the current allocation (■350 cr), NOT 10 percentage points added to 35%.

Q3 Correct Answer: (D) +2.00

5.

Why others are wrong: A, B and C are all directly inferable from the passage.

The passage NEVER mentions India's position on the Durand Line. It discusses Pakistan, Afghanistan and the Taliban. India's view on the Durand Line cannot be inferred from this passage — making D an inference that CANNOT be drawn. A is inferable (never recognised by any Afghan government ✓). B is inferable (divided Pashtun communities ✓). C is inferable (Taliban disputes Durand Line despite being Pakistan's ally ✓).

SECTION B — MODEL ANSWER OUTLINES (Q36–Q39 | Attempt any 3 | 10 Marks each)

Q36 — Model Answer Outline

Non-Alignment → Multi-Alignment: Continuity and Change in India's Strategic Autonomy

GS-2 | International Relations | 10 Marks | 150 words

INTRODUCTION (2-3 lines)

- Strategic autonomy has been India's constant foreign policy goal since 1947; the instrument has evolved, not the goal.

CONTINUITY — what stayed the same

- No formal military alliances (India is not in NATO, CSTO, or any defence treaty bloc)
- Independent foreign policy decisions (Ukraine: India abstained at UNGA; bought Russian oil despite Western pressure)
- Protection of national interest as the primary determinant
- Commitment to multipolarity and equitable world order

CHANGE — what evolved

- From ideological neutrality (equidistance) to pragmatic equi-engagement
- From collective NAM identity to bilateral issue-based partnerships
- From avoidance of great powers to calibrated engagement (Jaishankar: 'India belongs to multiple intersecting circles')
- From passive non-alignment to active multi-alignment (QUAD + SCO simultaneously)

KEY EXAMPLES

- Defence: US (GSOMIA, COMCASA, BECA, iCET), Russia (S-400), France (Rafale) — all simultaneously
- Energy: Russia oil at discount post-Ukraine; OPEC+ relations maintained
- India-France SGSP (2023), India-US Initiative for Critical and Emerging Technologies (iCET)

CONCLUSION

- Multi-alignment is evolution not reversal — strategic autonomy preserved, tools updated for a multipolar world.

Q37 — Model Answer Outline

GS-2 | India and its Neighbourhood | 10 Marks | 150 words

INTRODUCTION

- SAARC (1985, Dhaka Charter) — 8 members, 1.9 bn people, \$3+ tn GDP — yet minimal progress in 40 years.

STRUCTURAL FACTORS

- Consensus-based decision-making: any 1 of 8 can veto (India-Pakistan disagreement = paralysis)
- No dispute-resolution or enforcement mechanism (unlike WTO panels or ASEAN AIPA)
- No SAARC Free Trade Area effectively functional; SAFTA utilisation < 5%
- Secretariat is weak — no budget autonomy, no implementation authority

POLITICAL FACTORS

- India-Pakistan: no SAARC summit since 2016 (Pakistan); India boycotted Islamabad summit
- Small state fear of Indian hegemony — Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka strategic hedging toward China
- Domestic politics: Pakistan's 'strategic depth' doctrine makes India-Pakistan normalisation structurally difficult

BIMSTEC (Alternative Assessment)

- 7 members: excludes Pakistan; bridges South and Southeast Asia; Bay of Bengal connectivity
- More functional: Master Plan on Connectivity, BIMSTEC secretariat (Dhaka), trade negotiations
- BUT: limited funding, no real FTA yet, Myanmar military government complicates

BBIN (Sub-Regional Alternative)

- Bangladesh-Bhutan-India-Nepal; Motor Vehicles Agreement (MVA); energy connectivity
- Bhutan's non-participation stalls MVA but bilateral India-Bangladesh cooperation robust

CONCLUSION

- Sub-regional mechanisms outperform SAARC in functionality but cannot replace full regional integration — which remains hostage to India-Pakistan relations.

Q38 — Model Answer Outline

Stability-Instability Paradox: Nuclear Deterrence in South Asia

GS-2/GS-3 | Nuclear Deterrence | 10 Marks | 150 words

INTRODUCTION

- Glenn Snyder's 'stability-instability paradox' (1965): macro-level nuclear peace enables micro-level conventional instability.
- South Asia's nuclear deterrence (since May 1998 Pokhran II + Chagai tests) is the world's most active example.

THE STABILITY DIMENSION

- No full-scale conventional war since Bangladesh Liberation War (1971)
- Nuclear deterrence 'works' at the strategic level — neither side wants mutual assured destruction
- Kargil 1999: contained at conventional level despite extreme provocation
- No nuclear exchange despite 4 major crises (1999, 2001-02, 2008, 2019)

THE INSTABILITY DIMENSION

- Pakistan sponsors proxy groups (LeT — Mumbai 2008; JeM — Pulwama 2019) calculating India cannot escalate conventionally
- Cross-LoC infiltration, IED planting, radicalisation — all sub-nuclear threshold activities
- Kargil itself: a conventional military intrusion under nuclear shadow
- Pakistan's Nasr (Hatf-IX) tactical nuclear missile: lowers nuclear threshold, deepens paradox

HOW THE PARADOX WORKS (mechanism)

- Pakistan's logic: conventional retaliation by India risks nuclear escalation → India deterred → proxy war 'safe'
- India's dilemma: punish Pakistan conventionally? risk nuclear; don't punish? proxy war continues

- Cold Start Doctrine (sub-conventional response) is India's attempt to find a space below nuclear threshold
- Balakot (2019): non-military strike crossing LoC — testing the threshold

CONCLUSION

- Paradox persists as long as Pakistan's nuclear arsenal deters conventional Indian retaliation — making South Asia uniquely dangerous.

Q39 — Model Answer Outline

Lahore Declaration + Shimla Agreement: Why Bilateral Agreements Fail in South Asia

GS-2 | India-Pakistan Relations | 10 Marks | 150 words

INTRODUCTION

- Lahore Declaration (1999) and Shimla Agreement (1972) — two landmark peace frameworks, both ultimately ineffective.

SHIMLA AGREEMENT (1972) — Significance

- Indira Gandhi + Zulfikar Ali Bhutto
- Created Line of Control from ceasefire line — legitimised India's control
- Rejected UN plebiscite mechanism — bilateralised Kashmir dispute
- Released 93,000 Pakistani PoWs — India's goodwill gesture

LAHORE DECLARATION (1999) — Significance

- Post-nuclear tests (1998) — only nuclear risk reduction framework between the two
- Nuclear hotlines, advance missile test notifications, composite dialogue
- Symbolism: PM Vajpayee's Lahore bus journey — highest civilian outreach

WHY AGREEMENTS FAIL — 4 structural reasons

- (1) Civil-military disconnect in Pakistan: Army runs foreign/defence policy; Kargil launched 3 months after Lahore Declaration
- (2) No verification or enforcement mechanism: bilateral only, no third-party monitoring
- (3) Core dispute (Kashmir) unresolved: agreements address symptoms, not the cause
- (4) Domestic politics: every terror attack resets trust to zero (Parliament 2001, Mumbai 2008, Pulwama 2019)

CONCLUSION

- Durable peace requires structural change in Pakistan's civil-military balance — formal agreements without this are fragile.

SECTION C — MODEL ANSWER OUTLINES (Q40–Q41 | Both Compulsory | 20 Marks each)

Q40 — Model Answer Outline

India-China Strategic Competition: Territorial, Economic, Diplomatic and Maritime Dimensions

GS-2 | India-China Relations | Indo-Pacific | 20 Marks | 250 words

INTRODUCTION (3-4 lines)

- India-China: from 'Hindi-Chini bhai bhai' (1950s) to 'competitive coexistence' (post-2020). Galwan Valley clash (June 15, 2020: 20 Indian soldiers killed) marked a qualitative shift.

DIMENSION 1: TERRITORIAL

- 3,488-km LAC (Line of Actual Control) — not demarcated; different perceptions in 3 sectors
- Galwan (2020), Doklam (2017), Depsang, Demchok — friction points
- Arunachal Pradesh: China calls it 'South Tibet'; regularly 'renames' its towns (Zangnan)
- Aksai Chin (40,000 sq km) — under Chinese control; India claims it

DIMENSION 2: ECONOMIC

- Trade deficit: ~\$85 billion (FY2024); India = major importer of electronics, pharma APIs
- FDI Press Note 3 (2020): mandates Govt approval for Chinese FDI after Galwan
- BRI: China invested in neighbours (Pakistan-CPEC, Sri Lanka-Hambantota, Nepal-BRI roads)
- India refused to join BRI — sovereignty concerns over CPEC/Gilgit-Baltistan

DIMENSION 3: DIPLOMATIC

- China blocks India's UNSC permanent seat bid; uses Pakistan as proxy to block India at UN
- Masood Azhar (JeM): China blocked UNSC listing 4 times before relenting in 2019
- SCO membership: both India and Pakistan are members — managed multilateral interaction
- Five-Point Consensus (Jaishankar-Wang Yi, 2020): framework for LAC de-escalation

DIMENSION 4: MARITIME

- String of Pearls: Gwadar (Pak), Hambantota (Sri Lanka), Chittagong (Bangladesh), Kyaukpyu (Myanmar)
- PLAN has ~355 ships; Indian Ocean patrols increasing; Djibouti military base (2017)
- China's Maritime Silk Road — port investments in IORA region

INDIA'S MANAGEMENT STRATEGY

- Strategic balancing: QUAD (US-Japan-Australia) + SCO (China-Russia) simultaneously
- Border infra: BRO roads, advanced landing grounds, Galwan led to 61 infra projects
- Economic decoupling: PLI scheme to reduce API/electronics dependence on China
- Diplomatic: Wuhan (2018) + Mamallapuram (2019) informal summits; Kazsan (2024)

CONCLUSION

- India manages China through competitive coexistence — competing where interests clash, cooperating where compatible (BRICS, SCO). The border issue requires resolution for normalisation.

Q41 — Model Answer Outline

Indus Waters Treaty: Strategic Dimensions, Abeyance Decision and Water Diplomacy Options

GS-2/GS-3 | Water Diplomacy | India-Pakistan | 20 Marks | 250 words

INTRODUCTION

- IWT (1960): Brokered by World Bank; often called 'one of the world's most successful water treaties' — survived 3 wars. Now under unprecedented stress after India's 2025 abeyance decision post-Pahalgam terror attack.

STRATEGIC DIMENSIONS OF IWT

- Eastern rivers (Ravi, Beas, Sutlej) → India's exclusive use; Western rivers (Indus, Jhelum, Chenab) → Pakistan's use
- ~80% of Pakistan's irrigated agriculture depends on IWT waters — existential for Pakistan
- India controls all headwaters — enormous strategic leverage
- Kishenganga HPP (J&K) and Ratle HPP: Pakistan challenged at Permanent Court of Arbitration (PCA, The Hague)
- Baglihar Dam (Chenab): World Bank Neutral Expert ruled in India's favour (2007)

INDIA'S ABEYANCE DECISION

- Trigger: Pahalgam terror attack (April 2025, 26 tourists killed, Pakistani link established)
- India declared IWT 'in abeyance' — not formal termination but suspension of obligations

LEGAL ANALYSIS

- India's basis: Vienna Convention on Law of Treaties (VCLT) — material breach (state-sponsored terrorism) + fundamental change of circumstances
- Problem: India is not VCLT signatory (customary international law applies partially)
- IWT has no unilateral exit clause; World Bank is a party — legal challenge complex
- Pakistan: went to PCA; international sympathy as downstream state; existential framing
- International Water Law: Helsinki Rules, UN Watercourses Convention — favour equitable sharing

INDIA'S POLICY OPTIONS

- (1) Infrastructure build-up: Construct storage on Western rivers (Tulbul project, Sawalkote Dam) — decades needed
- (2) Treaty renegotiation: Invoke climate change + new hydrological reality as basis for renegotiation
- (3) Conditional engagement: Link IWT compliance to Pakistan's anti-terror action — diplomatic leverage
- (4) Slow-burn pressure: Delay PCA, stall Permanent Indus Commission meetings — signal costs without formal violation

CONCLUSION

- Water as strategic tool has high leverage but high legal and reputational costs. India must build physical infrastructure capacity to convert legal threats into real policy capability — 'abeyance' without infrastructure development is a symbolic gesture, not strategic action.

SECTION D — ESSAY OUTLINES (Q42/Q43 | Attempt ONE | 25 Marks)

Q42 — Model Answer Outline

Essay Choice 1: 'Strategic autonomy is not isolationism but principled engagement'

GS-2 Essay | International Relations | 25 Marks | 1000-1200 words

THESIS (establish in Para 1)

- Strategic autonomy = India's active engagement with all major powers on its OWN terms — not passive withdrawal from world affairs.

PARA 1: Historical roots

- Panchsheel (1954): peaceful coexistence, sovereignty, non-interference
- NAM (1961, Bandung): Nehru's vision — moral force without military bloc
- Criticism: NAM = passive, unable to prevent 1962 Chinese aggression

PARA 2: Cold War and post-1991 transition

- Tilt toward USSR (1971 Treaty): realpolitik under strategic necessity
- 1991 balance of payments crisis → liberalisation → US engagement begins
- Pokhran 1998: asserted nuclear autonomy despite Western sanctions

PARA 3: Multi-alignment in practice (21st century)

- USA: Foundational agreements (GSOMIA, COMCASA, BECA), ICET, QUAD, GE-HAL jet engine deal
- Russia: S-400 despite CAATSA threat; oil purchases despite G7 pressure; defence legacy
- France: Rafale, SGSP 2023, civil nuclear (Jaitapur), ISRO-CNES
- China: BRICS, SCO, trade — even while competing at LAC

PARA 4: Case studies of autonomy in action

- Ukraine vote: India abstained consistently — neither endorsed Russia nor condemned
- QUAD + SCO simultaneously: engaged with US-led security AND China-Russia multilateralism
- G20 presidency: African Union inclusion — independent 'Global South' voice

PARA 5: Philosophical dimension

- Nehruvian idealism (moral world order) → Kautilyan realism (national interest) → synthesis
- Jaishankar: 'India belongs to multiple intersecting circles' — not one exclusive sphere
- Distinction: equidistance (passive) vs equi-engagement (active)

CONCLUSION

- In a fragmenting world, India's multi-alignment is not fence-sitting but sophisticated statecraft — building maximum partnerships while retaining maximum freedom. Strategic autonomy is the Indian answer to bipolarity's demand for alignment.

Q43 — Model Answer Outline

Essay Choice 2: 'The neighbourhood is not merely geography but destiny'

GS-2 Essay | India and South Asia | 25 Marks | 1000-1200 words

THESIS

- India's rise and South Asian stability are inseparable — India cannot become a global power while surrounded by fragile, hostile or China-dependent neighbours.

PARA 1: Geography as strategic fate

- 8 neighbours; longest borders in Asia; shared civilisational heritage (Buddhism, Islam, Hindu traditions)
- 2 billion people in one security complex — South Asia's stability is India's stability

PARA 2: The trust deficit problem

- India's size creates 'big brother' perception among neighbours
- Nepal: 2015 blockade (India's response to Madhesi crisis) caused lasting resentment
- Sri Lanka: India's support for LTTE early + betrayal during final Eelam War
- Bangladesh: Teesta water dispute stalls otherwise positive bilateral

PARA 3: China's encirclement strategy

- String of Pearls + BRI: Gwadar, Hambantota, Chittagong, Kyaukpyu
- Nepal's infrastructure tilt toward China; Bhutan boundary deal talks
- Bangladesh's Tk 1 trillion BRI engagement (roads, bridges)
- Pakistan: CPEC deepens China's military proximity to India

PARA 4: India's evolving neighbourhood policy

- Gujral Doctrine (1996): non-reciprocity — give more than take
- Neighbourhood First (2014): PM Modi's first bilateral visits; SAARC invite
- SAGAR (2015): 'Security and Growth for All in the Region'
- 2022 Sri Lanka: India's \$4 bn emergency lifeline during economic collapse — genuine goodwill

PARA 5: New framework needed

- Move beyond aid-donor model to integration — BIMSTEC connectivity, power trading, digital integration
- Address asymmetry problem: smaller neighbours need 'voice' not just 'cheques'
- India-Bangladesh model: 2+2 dialogue, connectivity, power, defence cooperation — template for region

PARA 6: India's rise or fall is regional

- Unstable neighbourhood = resource drain (security costs, refugee flows, terrorism spillover)
- India cannot project global power while managing Kabul-Islamabad-Kathmandu-Colombo simultaneously as adversaries

CONCLUSION

- Geography assigned India its neighbourhood; history complicated it; the 21st century demands India transcend both — not through dominance but through partnership. Destiny is not fixed; it is built.

— END OF ANSWER KEY —

Total MCQ Marks: 70 | Section B: 30 | Section C: 40 | Section D: 25 | Grand Total: 165